

Empathy Map — The Visionary Staller

Empathy Map

v1.0

You

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Approved

THINKS

- "Should I get a dot journal? Learn Figma? Set up GitHub? What's the tech stack?"
- "This idea might not even be good the more I think about it."
- "This is a jigsaw puzzle with no picture on the box."
- "Sixth graders already know more than me about this."
- "I need a Sherlock mind palace."

FEELS

- Foggy stupor — low-grade paralysis before the spark
- Euphoric clarity at the POW moment — brief, intense
- Overwhelmed immediately after — can't capture fast enough
- Shame and self-doubt — 'is this a hobby or a career?'
- Physical restlessness — uncomfortable, hungry, can't settle
- Excitement and dread simultaneously

SAYS

- "I need to research each of these competing ideas first."
- "Maybe music will help. Maybe a new notebook."
- "I should be looking for jobs. My resume is terrible."
- "I'm already going down the rabbit hole."
- "I don't have enough time — but I'm not doing anything else."

DOES

- Opens a Google Doc — writes word salad — edits — loses thread
- Spirals into tool research instead of doing the work
- Daydreams, gets distracted, eats something
- Generates feature ideas mid-task — can't stop the flood
- Starts new tangents before finishing current thought
- Eventually abandons session — idea stays in head only

PAINS

- No single clear starting point — always feels like the middle
- Too many tasks visible at once — triggers shutdown
- Unknown unknowns feel infinite and threatening
- Every tool requires a learning curve before use
- No way to capture the burst before it fades
- Self-judgment compounds every moment of friction

GAINS SOUGHT

- One obvious next step — no decision required
- A fast capture tool that thinks at burst speed
- Visible proof of progress — even tiny increments
- Someone (or something) holding the map — so they don't have to
- Permission to be in the middle without shame
- The fog clearing just enough to take one step

CORE DESIGN INSIGHT EXTRACTED FROM THIS MAP

PM Dev must show exactly one prompt at a time. It must hide the full scope. It must reward the first answer immediately with visible progress. It must provide a safe container for the burst — fast capture without structure — and then organize it quietly in the background.